

PTI



LET THE LIGHT IN
From far left, CM Eknath Shinde and Uddhav Thackeray lead rival Dussehra rallies of their Shiv Sena factions in Mumbai, Oct. 12

MANDAR DEODHAR

Advantage Shinde

- Shinde faction still has support of the lion's share of Sena leaders/legislators
- CM Shinde claims credit for new welfare schemes worth Rs 90,000 cr., including Ladki Bahin for poor women
- EC votes in his favour, hands him original Shiv Sena name and 'bow and arrow' symbol
- Didn't do too badly in LS poll, won 7 of 15 seats contested

Advantage Uddhav

- Thackeray name and sympathy factor are still Shiv Sena (UBT)'s trump cards
- The party hopes its narrative on Shinde and his "gaddar (traitor) MLAs" splitting the party will find traction
- Do-or-die battle cry may lead to Shiv Sena faithful coalescing around Uddhav
- Party has managed transfer of Muslim, Congress vote

Commission recognised his faction as the real Shiv Sena and allotted him the party symbol, the bow and arrow, leaving Uddhav to look for a new symbol for his SS(UBT)—a flaming torch.

In the Lok Sabha election, the battle for the real Shiv Sena ended in a draw—the SS(UBT) secured nine seats, just two more than the Shinde Sena. Round two will be a winner-takes-all battle for the legacy of Balasaheb Thackeray and the Shiv Sena. Alarm bells have been ringing in the Thackeray-led Sena, which saw an erosion in its core Marathi support base in the Mumbai, Konkan and Marathwada regions in the LS election. It managed to romp home in some seats, but largely due to the support of the Muslims, with whom they had once had a bristling relationship. SS(UBT) leaders are hoping their narrative about Shinde and his "*gaddar* (traitor) MLAs" splitting the party for power and pelf will find traction this election. They also reason that some of the party's core voters may have "voted Modi" in the LS poll, but will revert to core loyalties for the state election.

The Shinde-led Sena, in turn, says the rollout of the Rs 90,000 crore-plus worth of welfare schemes will counter any sympathy for Thackeray or the MVA. Shinde has also stolen a march over allies BJP and the NCP in claiming credit, especially of the flagship Mukhyamantri Majhi Ladki Bahin Yojana, where some 25 million women from poor families are set to get a monthly dole of Rs 1,500. The Shiv Sainik from Thane will fancy